

Younus

SAJAN: WHAT WAS THE SITUATION OF THE NORMAL PEOPLE, LIKE WHAT DID THEY DO AND HOW DID THEY EXPERIENCE WAR

MAHEER:

as you have already heard about how the ordinary peoples were during the war and liberation war and how thirty million people were displaced from the country and ten million went to refugees. Now I wanna talk about who were those ordinary people because as you know, our history is mostly exclusive, and it really tries to talk about the politics and the political leaders and their works. But we wanna talk about the inclusive history So I wanna talk about what... who where those villages... who where those ordinary people live in the villages of Bangladesh, and how did they experience the war?

That was the human cost of the war.

slightly different angle. **what did the villagers themselves do during the war?**

Because if we only talk about their suffering, we may see villagers only as victims — people who SIMPLY EXPERIENCED THE WAR But the reality was more complicated.

Afsan Chowdhury explains this idea in the introduction of গ্রামের একাত্তর or *Gramer Ekattor*.

He says that the history of a country's birth has two parts. One part is

about the government, army, politicians, and freedom fighters.

The other part is about ordinary people and local communities — what they actually did during the war.

Both parts are important. But we know much less about the second part.

did not write down their experiences, and there were very few official documents about what happened in villages. That is the gap that *Gramer Ekattor* tries to fill.

The absence of the history of these people, the book of our respected AFSAN CHOWDHURY grammar ekattor book where he talked about the ordinary people who are missing the pages of history. So he said that the villages were used as shelters for the people..... as we know Mostly Bengal people lived in villages in 1971 and when the initial attack was on the big cities, they actually fled to villages for refuge and danger.

In occupation, there were farmers, there were deliveries, fishermen, boatmen, porter, blacksmith, imam or school teachers. They lived very ordinary life and made money with working normal jobs.

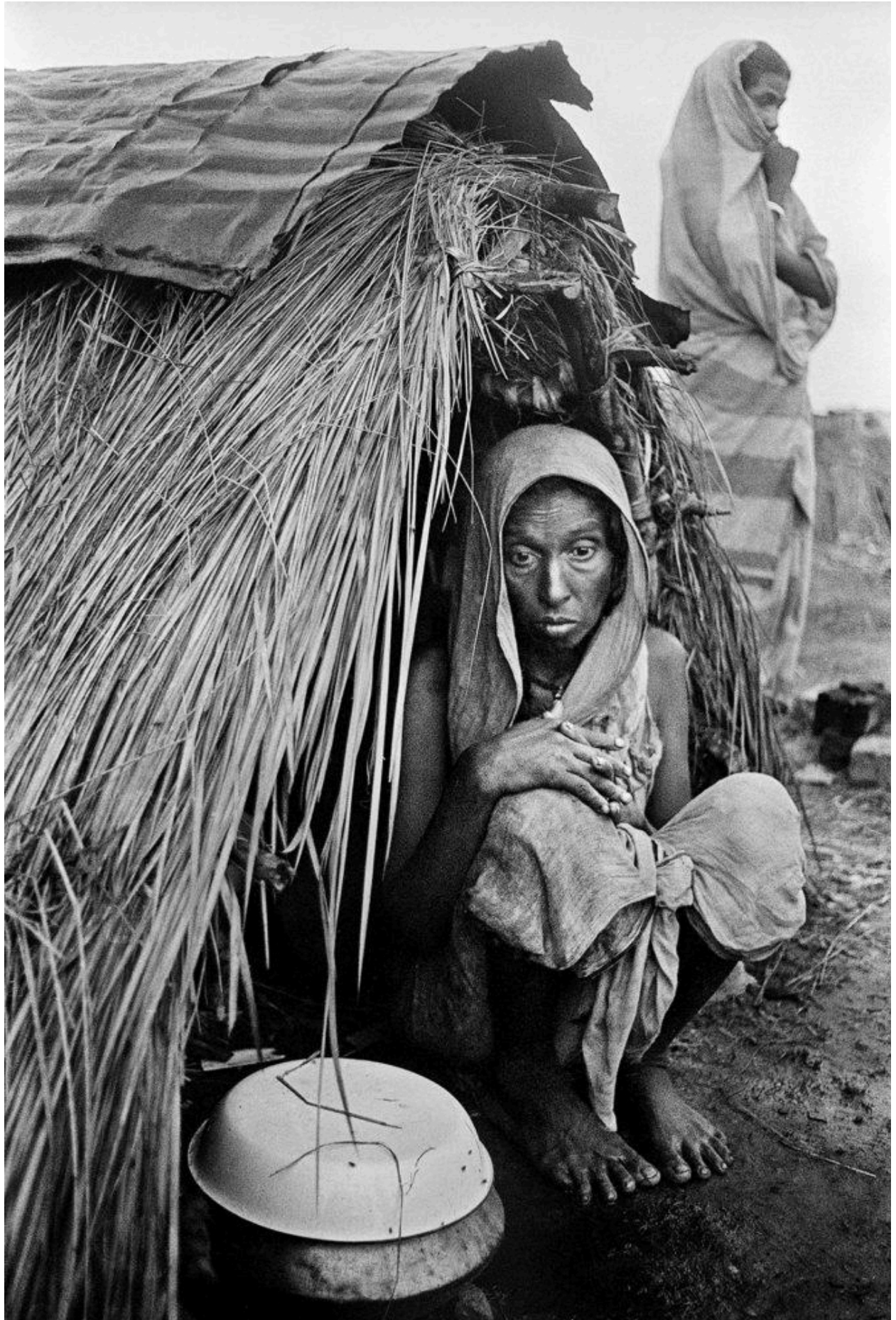
But there was something exceptional role about them,,, the Mukhtibahini, the freedom fighters, used villages as a method of shelter food information and traveling to India. So villages were not in the background. They were actually very important position for our country, independence

I wanna talk about the story of my uncle, my elder uncle, who was a freedom fighter, and he was a young adult at that time. And when the war broke out, he actually went to Darjeeling for training for the Liberation War, and he actually towards the ending... towards the end of the Liberation War. It was really cold, and he really was suffering a lot. And my father tells me the story that their family actually was really worried about how he was doing in India.

They were also worried about the situation of the country in the liberation war. And he quoted that many Hindu families actually lived with us. We were Muslims, but there were many Hindu families that were living in our houses and also other Muslim peoples leaving our house. So there was no division religious discriminations, and people were really focused on living and didn't think about it otherwise.

Paki army didnt hold back on the villagers

They actually started raiding the village and started to torture the villages for information about Mukhtibahines and etc They used to loot villages after villages, and the villages were ordinary people, and they didn't have much to fight back. So it was a merciless operation from the Pakistani soldiers. and **YASMIN SAIKIN** and **Nayanika Mookherjee** also explained the role of women that they were also the caretakers and they were also standing in line for... were very helping the Mukdipahinus as mothers and sisters. So at the conclusion, if we take every villages into account, it can be seen that villages together, they represent a large part of history that is not known to the people, and it was one of the main battlefields of the Bangladeshi liberation.







Sharmishta

The Reality of Village Life During the Liberation War

When we talk about the Liberation War of 1971, we often imagine the battlefield. But for ordinary village people, the war was happening right inside their homes and around them.

Imagine waking up every morning not knowing whether you would be alive by the end of the day. People were afraid of army raids. They would hide in fields, forests, or in other people's houses. Sometimes, they had to leave their village and move to another one when they heard that the army was coming. According to The Daily Star, around 30 million people were internally displaced, meaning they had to leave their homes and search for safety somewhere else.

Normal life completely broke down. Farmers could not safely work in their fields. Families struggled to find food and basic necessities. Homes and villages were sometimes burned, and people lost their belongings and their source of income. For many families, survival became more important than anything else.

Women suffered especially badly. They were not only afraid of being killed or losing their families; many were also exposed to sexual violence. The Daily Star has documented individual stories of village women who were taken from their homes, tortured, and sexually abused. One survivor, Biva Rani, described how she and other women hid in a sugarcane field, but they were discovered and taken by Pakistani soldiers.

And then there were those who had to leave the country. Around 10 million people fled to India as refugees. They travelled long distances, often on foot or by boat, carrying very few belongings. Refugee camps were also extremely difficult places, with shortages of food and medicine and the spread of diseases.

So, for an ordinary village family, the Liberation War was not something happening far away on a battlefield. The battlefield was their home. It meant hiding from soldiers, leaving their homes, losing their farms and belongings, living without enough food, and constantly wondering whether they would survive.

And despite all of this fear and suffering, ordinary people continued to help the freedom fighters and support the struggle for an independent Bangladesh.

That is the human story of 1971—the story not only of those who fought with guns, but also of millions of ordinary people who simply tried to survive.



The Daily Star



Tasmiah

City life during the Liberation War of 1971 in urban centers like Dhaka and Chittagong was defined by constant fear, military surveillance, severe shortages and sudden violence.

Daily Life in cities During the Liberation War

After March 1971, Dhaka's normal life changed dramatically. People joined protests and strikes, while offices, schools, factories, courts, and transport services closed. The Pakistani government imposed curfews and used violence, creating fear and insecurity (Daily Star, 2019).

During the war, civilians faced food shortages, power cuts, gunfire, army raids, rumours of killings and constant fear. Despite these difficulties, people tried to continue their daily lives and remained hopeful for independence. Jahanara Imam's Ekattorer Dinguli and Muhammad Shamsul Huda's Abaruddha Dhaka provide personal accounts of this difficult period.

Pakistani Raids, Curfews and Fear

After 25 March 1971, curfews became a major part of daily life in Dhaka. During Operation Searchlight, the army arrested Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and imposed a curfew. On 26 March, the streets were almost empty as soldiers and army vehicles patrolled the city. When the curfew was briefly lifted on 27 March, many people used the chance to buy essential goods or escape to safer places (Muhammad, 2025).

The Pakistani Army carried out systematic searches and arrests, especially targeting students, Awami League supporters, intellectuals, police, and Bengali military personnel. Soldiers checked people at places such as Farmgate and attacked those who built roadblocks. They also restricted communication by controlling or cutting telephone, radio, television, and teleprinter services (The Daily Star, n.d.).

Radio as a Source of Information

Radio was one of the main ways people got news during the war because it could reach even remote areas. The Pakistani government controlled newspapers and other media, so information was limited. Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra broadcast the Declaration of Independence. It began with the words, "Swadhin Bangla Biplobi Betar Kendra Theke Ami Major Zia Balchhi" ("I am Major Zia speaking from Swadhin Bangla Biplobi Betar Kendra"). These broadcasts helped people know what was happening and gave them courage (Haider, 2025).

Economic Impact

The Liberation War seriously damaged the economy. Many shops and businesses closed because of fighting and curfews. Factories could not get raw materials, so many

workers lost their jobs and income. Food production and transportation were disrupted, causing serious food shortages and higher prices. Poor families suffered the most because they could not afford basic food and had very little income left after buying necessities (Kann, 2018).

Student Resistance and Youth Disappearance

From the late 1940s to 1971, students and young people played a key role in Bangladesh's struggle for freedom. They led major movements such as the Language Movement, Education Movement, Six-Point Movement, and 1969 Mass Uprising. In 1971, many young people went beyond protests and joined the Liberation War as freedom fighters and supporters. Young people from different groups—including students, farmers, workers, professionals, police officers, and activists—participated in the resistance, while thousands crossed the border to receive military training. Shafi Imam Rumi, son of Jahanara Imam, was one notable example of a young person who left his family to join the Mukti Bahini (Jameel, 2021).

Intellectual Killings

The intellectual killings were one of the most tragic parts of the 1971 Liberation War. In December 1971, especially from around 10 December, the local collaborators such as Al-Badr and Al-Shams, with the support of the Pakistan Army. Major General A.A.K. Niazi was the commander of the Pakistan Army's Eastern Command, while Lt. General Rao Farman Ali was responsible for civil administration and has been linked to the operations against intellectuals. They abducted and killed Bengali professors, journalists, doctors, engineers, artists and other educated professionals. More than 200 intellectuals were reportedly taken from their homes, tortured, and later found dead at Rayer Bazar on 14 December. The purpose was to weaken the new country by removing its educated and influential people (Hoque, 2017).

Cultural Resistance: Radio, Songs and Poetry

During the Liberation War, patriotic songs became a powerful tool of resistance. Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra broadcast inspirational songs and messages that encouraged both civilians and freedom fighters. It first operated secretly from Kalurghat, Chittagong, and later broadcast from Kolkata from 25 May 1971. Also, Akashbani Kolkata broadcast Bangladeshi artists and liberation songs, helping spread the message of independence and strengthen Bengali nationalism.

Poetry also played an important role. Many Bengali poets wrote poems about the war, suffering, injustice and the struggle for independence. Some poems were later turned into songs and became very popular through Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra. (History for Peace, 2021).

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Nusayba

Main Speech:

Even before the war, people in East Pakistan faced deep economic and political inequality. Although East Pakistan contributed significantly to Pakistan's economy through exports such as jute, resources, development, and political power were largely concentrated in West Pakistan. This created a growing feeling that the people of East Pakistan were being denied their fair share and their right to govern themselves. (*The Daily Star – historical analysis*). For ordinary people who were dependent on farming, small businesses, or regular jobs, these inequalities directly affected their everyday lives and opportunities.

People hoped democracy would bring change. They voted overwhelmingly for the Awami League, expecting their elected representatives to govern. But power was not handed over to the elected majority, which deepened the political crisis and pushed the country closer to conflict. (*Law and History Review, Cambridge*)

Everything changed on the night of March 25th, when the Pakistan Army launched **Operation Searchlight**. The attack on Dhaka University is widely remembered, but Rajarbagh Police Lines, the EPR headquarters at Pilkhana, and other parts of Dhaka were also targeted. In one night, a political crisis turned into open military violence. (*The Daily Star – Operation Searchlight archive*)

Fear spread quickly. People fled their homes and families were separated. But people did not only flee. Students and young people joined the liberation struggle, many becoming part of the **Mukti Bahini**. Ordinary people supported the fighters with food, shelter and information. The Liberation War gradually became a people's struggle. (*The Daily Star – Resistance, Resilience and Redemption*)

As young people left to fight, families faced painful separation and uncertainty. Meanwhile, violence spread beyond the cities into rural areas. While some fought for independence, millions faced another struggle protecting their families and homes. And that brings us to the people in the villages, where simply surviving became a struggle of its own.

Even before the war, people in East Pakistan faced deep economic and political inequality. East Pakistan contributed significantly to Pakistan's economy, especially through exports like jute, but there was a long-standing gap in development and the distribution of resources between East and West Pakistan. Political power was also heavily concentrated in the western wing. These inequalities gradually created a strong

feeling that the people of East Pakistan were being denied their fair share and their right to govern themselves. (The Daily Star – historical analysis)

For ordinary people, most of whom depended on farming, small businesses, or regular jobs, these issues were not just political debates. They affected everyday opportunities and livelihoods.

People hoped that change could finally come peacefully through democracy. They voted overwhelmingly for the Awami League, expecting that their elected representatives would be allowed to govern. But power was not handed over to the elected majority. The refusal to respect that democratic mandate deepened the political crisis and pushed the country closer to conflict. (Law and History Review, Cambridge)

Everything changed on the night of March 25th, when the Pakistan Army launched Operation Searchlight. We often hear about the attack on Dhaka University, but the crackdown was much wider. Rajarbagh Police Lines, the EPR headquarters at Pilkhana, residential areas, and other important locations across Dhaka were also targeted. In just one night, a political crisis turned into open military violence. (The Daily Star – Operation Searchlight archive)

There was fear and uncertainty. People fled their homes, trying to find somewhere safe. Normal life was suddenly disrupted, and families had to think first about protecting themselves and their loved ones. Ordinary people were no longer simply watching a political crisis unfold—they were now directly living through the consequences of war.

But people did not only flee. Students and young men also joined the liberation struggle, with many becoming part of the Mukti Bahini. Ordinary people supported the fighters too by providing food, shelter, information, and safe places to stay. The Liberation War gradually became a people's struggle, involving people from different parts of society. (The Daily Star – Resistance, Resilience and Redemption)

As young men left to join the Mukti Bahini, many families faced separation and uncertainty. And as the military crackdown continued, violence spread beyond the major cities and into rural areas.

While some people joined the resistance and fought for independence, millions of ordinary people were left trying to protect their families, homes, and everyday lives. And that brings us to the experience of those living in the villages, where simply surviving became a struggle of its own.

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Shorter speech

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Sajan

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